women fetched a higher price and could be sold for concubinage. At the time of the Mughals, women slaves in the households of noblemen were called paristaran, or sahelis, and talented and beautiful sahelis were highly valued, leading to jealousies and intrigues exactly as happened in the case of Baz Bahadur's dancing girls.

After dealing with Adham Khan, the Mughal court made a more leisurely return to Agra, stopping to hunt and accept tributes from chieftains en route. Near Narwar, as the cortège was passing through a forest, a tigress with her cubs stepped on to the path in front of them. While his entourage froze with fear, Akbar walked up to the tigress and killed her with a single stroke of his sword, having in his arms the strength of 'the Lion of God'.

On returning to Agra, Akbar continued with his efforts to curb the powers of individual nobles. Accompanied by Munim Khan, he travelled eastwards towards the fiefs of two notoriously independent-minded brothers, Ali Quli Khan and Bahadur Khan, Uzbek clansmen who had travelled to Hindustan with Humayun. Akbar met with the brothers at a town called Kara, by the Ganga, where they submitted much tribute and a large number of elephants, who went by whimsical names such as Jag Mohan, Palta, and Dilshringar. When he returned to Agra, in August 1561, Akbar summoned Ataka Khan to court and, in a sign of a change of guard that would lead to a notorious murder, appointed his foster father wakil-e-saltanat in lieu of Munim Khan. Munim Khan's shambolic management of the state's finances could no longer be tolerated, nor could his complicit attitude towards Adham Khan. Adham Khan was recalled to the capital from Malwa, and 'Maham Anaga's heart which was distressed by the separation from her honoured son, was thereby comforted'. After observing his reckless behaviour in Malwa, Maham Anaga no doubt believed she would be able to watch over her errant son better in Agra.

Akbar's immediate and decisive reaction to Adham Khan's continued disobedience shows that he had understood the fatal flaw at the heart of the empire he had inherited. The nobility he had been bequeathed by Humayun contained a large majority of Turani officers. The high posts and honours had been commandeered by the Turanis, with the Persians, aside from Bairam Khan, contenting themselves with the role of scribes and minor officials. The Uzbek clan, the Ataka Khail* and Adham Khan's family, had all grown powerful and their clout would need to be curtailed. For the next ten years Akbar would work incessantly to dramatically change that